

Session 29: From Dark to Light (Eph. 5:3-14)

Key Takeaways

- There are two realities we can live in: light and dark. Light is the new humanity and new creation, and darkness is the old humanity and death. God's mercy allows us to come out from the powers and make a choice.
- God's wrath can be understood as God handing people over to their own self-destruction.

Leaving the Dark, Living in Light: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 5:3-14

³ But sexual immorality
and all impurity
or greedy desire,
should not be named among y'all,
as is fitting for holy ones,
⁴ also obscenity
or foolish talk
or inappropriate humor;
such things have no place,
but rather grateful thanksgiving.
⁵ For y'all should surely know this:
that no sexually immoral
or impure
or greedy person
(who is an idolator)
has an inheritance in the Kingdom of the Messiah and of God.
⁶ Let no one deceive you with empty words,
because on account of such things
the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience.
⁷ Therefore, do not participate with them.
⁸ For you were at one time darkness,
but now (you are) light in the Lord.
Walk as children of light
⁹ for the fruit of the light is in all goodness and justice and truth
¹⁰ discerning what it is that pleases the Lord,
¹¹ and don't share together
in the fruitless deeds of darkness,
but rather expose them.
¹² For what is done in hiding by them
is shameful even to mention,
¹³ but everything that is exposed by the light,
is made visible,
for everything that is made visible is light.
¹⁴ Therefore one says:
Awake, Sleeper!
Rise from among the dead ones!
And the Messiah will shine on you!

Ephesians 5:3-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Rhetorical Design Features in Ephesians 5:3-14

Ephesians 5:3-6: The passage develops the portrait of the old humanity of Ephesians 4:22 (contrasted with the new humanity of Eph. 4:23-24), which is summarized in terms of sex and idolatry.

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⁵ For y'all should surely know this:
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has an inheritance in the kingdom of the Messiah and of God.

⁶ Let no one deceive you with empty words. Because of these things the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience.

Ephesians 5:3-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

The triad sexual immorality, impurity, and greed is repeated three times, along with three assertions that such behaviors have no place in the new humanity both in the present (Eph. 5:2 "as is fitting for holy ones," Eph. 5:4 "aren't appropriate") and in the future (Eph. 5:5 "will have no inheritance in the Kingdom of the Messiah and of God").

Why These Three?

"The important idolatries have always centered on those forces which have enough specious power to be truly counterfeit, and therefore truly dangerous: sexuality (fertility), riches, and power (glory) ... All idolatry is a form of covetousness, for by refusing to acknowledge life and worth as a gift from the Creator, it seeks to seize them from the creation as booty. Sexual lust elevates the desired object, whether a person's own

gratification or another person, to the center of life and is antithetical to the thanksgiving which recognizes God at the center.”

Lincoln, Andrew T. (1990). [Word Biblical Commentary: Ephesians](#). Thomas Nelson Inc. 324.

Pattern of the Light in Ephesians 5:7-14

A 5:7 Do not be co-sharers with them

B 5:8a-b You are light

C 5:8c Walk as children of light

B' 5:9-10 The fruit of light is ...

A' 5:11a Do not be co-participants in the unfruitful works of darkness

a 5:11b but rather expose them

b 5:12 For the **things done** in hiding by them are shameful even to mention

c 5:13 but everything that is **exposed** by the **light** is made **visible**

d for everything that is made **visible** is **light**

Ephesians 5:6-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

This section is marked by a short symmetrical unit (Eph. 5:7-11a) focused around the contrast of darkness and light (from [Genesis 1](#)). It is framed by two prohibitions, “don’t be co-sharers” (συμμετοχος) and “don’t co-participate” (συγχοινωνειτε), with two inner statements about the light. And at the center is a positive command to embrace the reality of light. [This unit’s symmetrical design is also noted by Clinton E. Arnold in [Ephesians](#) (Arnold, 2010).] This is followed by a short stair-step unit (Eph. 5:11b-13), which increases the contrast between dark and light. Not only is light the opposite of darkness, it has the ability (and responsibility) to shine on the darkness in order to expose it to public view so that it can be seen for what it actually is.

The Poem in Ephesians 5:14

The final poem in Ephesians 5:14 is a quotation from a traditional poem or hymn about the call of the messianic age to those who are “dead” and are summoned to new resurrection life.

Ephesians 5:14 Instructor's Translation

Rise up O sleeper
Arise from the dead ones
and the Messiah will shine on you

In Greek:

ἔγειρε ὁ καθεύδων
καὶ ἀνάστα ἐκ τῶν νεκρῶν
καὶ ἐπιφαύσει σοι ὁ Χριστός

The language and poetic style is substantially informed by two texts: Isaiah 26:19 and Isaiah 60:1.

Isaiah 26:19 Instructor's Translation

Your dead ones will live,
my corpse they will rise;
awake and shout for joy
O sleepers in the dust,
for the dew of the light is your dew,
and the land will birth the spirits of the dead.

Isaiah 60:1 Instructor's Translation

Arise! Shine! For your light has come,
and the glory of Yahweh has risen over you!

Reflection Question

Instead of sexual immorality, greed, and foolish talking, Paul says to have “grateful thanksgiving.” How does thanksgiving counter these things?